

ARCHÆOLOGICAL.

RELICS OF THE ORIENTAL RACES OF CATALINA.

Interesting Discoveries Under the Hotel Metropole—Stone Implements, Earrings, Beads, Fish-hooks, Mortars, Pestles, Arts of the Aborigines, Etc.

AVALON (Catalina), Aug. 17.—
[Special Correspondence of THE TIMES.] Three hundred years ago, where the Hotel Metropole now stands, was a large and populous native village. Exactly who the people were and where they have gone to is one of the conundrums proposed to every visitor to the sea-girt isle.

This we do know, that the races who lived here have been utterly wiped out of existence to all intents and purposes, and no one can be found among the very aged people among the Indians of the mainland who will claim to be descendants of them.

Santa Catalina Island was discovered by Cabrillo in 1542, and named by him La Victoria, after one of his fleet. The present name of Catalina was given it by Vizcaino, who landed here in 1602, nearly 100 years later. An interesting account of Cabrillo's voyages, written by one of his pilots, has recently been found among old papers in Spain; but perhaps the most satisfactory account is of the voyage of Viz-

...plan, but perhaps the most satisfactory account is of the voyage of Vizcaino. He reports Catalina as being thickly populated, and makes especial mention of the fact that the people were adepts at stealing. Father Ascencion, who accompanied this expedition, recorded many interesting facts, and among them was a description of a "Temple of the Sun," said to be near the two harbors and to contain images and idols.

This temple was probably what first attracted the attention of scientific men in this direction, and nearly every year since the old padre's account has been translated some one has searched for it; but the account is so indefinite that the location has never been found, though some think it was upon San Clemente. The preponderance of opinion, however, is that it was on Catalina, and possibly the idols and images may have been covered up and will some day be unearthed.

The Indians or natives of Catalina had two or three principal settlements or villages, one on the site of the present Hotel Metropole, and the other at the isthmus, with smaller ones at different points where there was water.

The archaeological eye readily recognizes these locations by the peculiar nature of the soil, which looks as though it had been mixed with coal dust or burnt wood. The garden of the Metropole shows this, being made of earth full of bones, charred wood, ground shell; earth that has been lived on for centuries and been discolored by the occupation.

Eight or ten years ago Mexican Joe and old Billy were about the only occupants who lived here all the year round. They were familiar with the curious implements found here, but

round. They were familiar with the curious implements found here, but thought nothing of them. One day Prof. Schumacher, a representative of several eastern scientific museums and colleges, appeared on the scene. He hired Mexican Joe, and by the aid of charts and maps began a systematic series of excavations, which resulted in the collection of a fine lot of implements from this island, telling the complete history of the unknown inhabitants so far as their domestic habits were concerned.

Mexican Joe began to dig from the present Metropole Hotel site into what is now the street about where the swing stands, and the result was a bonanza to the scientist. At almost every shovelful some stone implement appeared. There were pestles made of hard stone, some from eight inches



to two feet in length, others short and thick. The long ones were used much as the apothecary grinds his medicine today, only with these people it was grain or seeds that were broken up or crushed. The long stone pestles or clubs being admirably suited for this purpose. They told the story of how at least their grain was crushed, which they probably obtained from the mainland.

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The grain must have been held in something, and scores of fine stone vessels or mortars, dug up here by the two excavators, told the story. They were of all sizes; some holding a peck, and two feet high, of soapstone from a quarry found five miles below Avalon.

Some were very small, holding very little, and they ranged from the largest size down to small ones three or four inches across, evidently intended as paint pots. Several hundred fine mortars were found in the Metropole site village, the shapes resembling those in the accompanying cut.



Stone Mortars

Only yesterday an excavation was being made for a new building, when a fine small mortar was dug up, which is of especial interest, as it bears on the side a small rude figure as shown it cut 3. It is the only figure so far found that could be considered as showing that these people had some idea of representing objects by a pencil. The figure, which of course may have been cut by a modern, though I was assured

by Mr. Kennedy that it was on the mortar when found, is a rude attempt at a human form, cut in the soft soap-stone with a knife or stone.



There are other ornaments upon the mortar, of various kinds.

Prof. Schumacher found hundreds of objects here: Oval stones, with stones in the center fairly polished, some of which can be seen in the billiard-room of the Metropole. What these are is a mystery, but, curiously enough, they are found among all the savage and prehistoric tribes of the world. The object which is shown in figure 3 is about three inches thick, and may have been used in a game of some kind, or as a weight to a digging stick. Some contend that they were sinkers or weights to nets, which would be a very plausible idea if there was any reason to believe that the people had large nets.

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These sinkers, as we will call them, are also found on the mainland far from the water. While sitting on the Metropole piazza the other day, I saw a gleam on the surface of the garden plot, and found that it was caused by several flatheads of abalone shell, really beautiful but very fragile objects—evidently worn by some dusky belle years ago. These beads, shown in cut No. 4, are remarkably symmetrical; in fact, perfect, and how they were made without tools is a mystery.

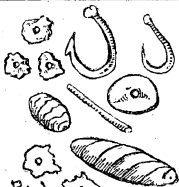
That these people were fond of display was very evident by the finds of Prof. Schumacher. Hundreds of abalone ornaments were found, cut in graceful curves; many carvings like fishhooks, pendants, curious-shaped stones, some like shoes, others like the human foot, while others seemed to have shapes that had no definite meaning. These, or many of them, can be seen in the curiosity store of Mr. Elms, the postmaster of Avalon, and hundreds of specimens were taken away by the collector referred to. In hunting other localities Prof. Schumacher found a soapstone quarry on the island, and a place where the mortars were made. Many of the latter were found incomplete or broken, just as they had been left, and undoubtedly here were made many of the large and beautiful mortars that have been found by collectors on the mainland. The Catalina people doubtless made them, or some of them, and traded with the Indians of the shore.

The natives were naturally dependent upon fish for a living, and fishhooks are found in great quantities, being made of abalone shell and resembling the modern hook, with the exception that in these ancient specimens the barb is upon the outside. Hundreds of these have been found about the Metropole grounds, and where the excavations were made for the foundations large quantities of material of all kinds were secured.

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The location at the isthmus was pre-eminently a burying-ground, and during a recent examination the writer unearthed a number of interesting objects. In working it was found that the bodies had been buried in about four layers, the lowest down being naturally the oldest. Here when a man dies many of the household gods were deposited with him. In digging carefully under a body I found that beads in large numbers had either been left around the neck of the deceased or thrown upon the body, probably the former, as when the earth was removed from beneath the skull the beads ran down in a stream. They were of all kinds—some large, with ornamentation, others of Venetian type, but mostly bits of shell perforated nicely and made from certain small shells. Though rude and rough it must have taken no little time to make them, and they were evidently valued, probably as money and ornaments as well.



Beads
Ornaments and
Fish Hooks

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I found a small section still strung upon some vegetable fiber, with pieces of copper wire coiled in a circle, evidently as rings, to connect the ends. Among the beads was one made from a human tooth; others from bones of birds.

The Venetian beads were identical with some I found being used by an aged Indian woman at San Gabriel Mission some time ago. She informed me that she obtained them from the old Mission fathers sixty or seventy years ago, and these beads we took from these Catalina graves were probably obtained from the same source.

That the ancient Catalinians were musical there is little doubt, as remains of numerous flutes were taken from these graves. Nearly all were broken, but I found one fairly perfect, one which showed the hole and the marks of asphaltum with which it had been wrapped. A perfect one given me by Mr. Elms, the postmaster at Avalon, which came from Clemente, shows that the instrument must have produced a very fair noise, as noises go. Prof. Schumacher took numbers of these here at various points. Some, as shown in the following cut, were

double and connected by a piece of asphaltum.



While some very fine flint spear-heads have been found here, the people were undoubtedly of a peaceful nature, seldom going to war. Arrow-heads are rare. In the grave at the isthmus I found a bone sword, which could only have been of use in some ceremonial, and it is known that swords made from the bones of whales were used.

Not the least interesting were the objects I took out that were obtained from the Spaniards, perhaps Cabrillo or Vazcaino themselves. One was a large iron ax, which Mr. H. N. Rust pronounced of Spanish type. It was covered with rust and scaled easily, but still shows the cloth that had been carefully wrapped around it.

but still shows the cloth that had been carefully wrapped around it. Another was an iron knife, which had been wrapped in a similar way, evidently a treasure, and buried with the owner. In the present article even an enumeration of the articles found could not be attempted, covering as they do every article used by these people, from paint and paint-pots up to the magnificent stone mortars that must have required years to make.

Where are the people or their descendants is an interesting problem. The last squaw was taken from San Nicholas Island some years ago, but San Clemente and Santa Catalina have not been inhabited within the memory of man. An aged Indian, claiming to be over 100, informed me that the natives were encouraged to leave here by the *padres*, who gave them homes about the missions, so that they could convert them. Others claim that they were killed off by disease. Mexican Joe says that when he came here, back in the '50s, Indian dogs were still running wild on the island. It is somewhat curious that so little is known about so interesting a subject, and one that, now the island bids fair to be such a famous resort, will grow in interest every year. KELL.